he declared the boundary issue to be a settled one that was "not open to argument or discussion, except perhaps with regard to minor tracts" and vowed not to give up India's "basic right" to preserve its frontiers even while pursuing a policy of "friendliness and co-existence" towards China.[41] The end result was that the 1954 agreement dealt exclusively with setting the new terms of India's interactions with Tibet in return for India recognising Tibet as a region of China and giving up its inherited privileges there.[42]

Territorial dispute and war

Although the *Panchsheel* agreement evoked hopes of friendship and brotherhood, it failed to serve as a foundation for peace because of the unsettled boundary issue. The boundary issue erupted into a full-blown territorial dispute in the latter half of 1958 after India discovered the Tibet–Sinkiang highway running through Ladakh's uninhabited Aksai Chin region over which China then began to assert ownership. The situation was made worse by the outbreak of the Tibetan revolt in March 1959 and the flight to India of the Dalai Lama and thousands of Tibetans.[43] In the wake of this development, China not only stepped up military patrols along the McMahon Line but also began to assert territorial claims over practically the whole of NEFA. India responded to Chinese territorial claims and military activities by stepping up its presence in both Ladakh and NEFA. It was under these circumstances that the first violent border incidents occurred, when the PLA used force to evict an Indian post in NEFA in August 1959 and followed it up by ambushing a patrol in Ladakh that killed nine Indian policemen and injured ten others.[44]

Neither direct talks between Nehru and Zhou in April 1960 nor subsequent discussions among officials about the basis